RFI26006369 - REQUEST FOR INFORMATION
Statewide Student Transportation Services for the State of Rhode Island

SECTION A. INTRODUCTION

The State is considering issuance of a Request for Proposals ("RFP") from qualified vendors to solicit bids for the Statewide Transportation Service for the RI Department of Elementary and Secondary Education ("RIDE"). Some of the goals of the upcoming RFP will be to:

- Provide….Review zones for bidding purposes.
- Service….Bid for zones that work best for all.
- Develop...Partnership between state and vendors.
- Deploy….Resources needed to accomplish transportation of school age children.

Goal:
RIDE is seeking input from qualified transportation providers in the development of an RFP for services to commence with the 2027-2028 school year. More information on the State's general conditions of purchase can be obtained here: https://ridop.ri.gov/

Objectives:

1. RIDE invites comments, suggestions and recommendations from potential vendors and other interested parties on any questions or issues raised in this Request for Information ("RFI"). Please note it is not a requirement to answer all questions.
2. Obtain alternative approaches and/or methodologies to accomplish the desired or intended results of this RFI are solicited.
3. This is an RFI, and as such no award will be made because of this solicitation.

All costs associated with developing or submitting responses to this RFI or providing oral or written clarification of the content of a response shall be borne by vendors. RIDE assumes no responsibility for the costs.

Interested parties are instructed to monitor the Division of Purchases website on a regular basis, as additional information relating to this solicitation may be released as addenda.

SECTION B: REQUEST FOR INFORMATION

Purpose:

The 2024 RI General Assembly created a Student Transportation Workgroup to recommend efficiency and cost reduction strategies for Local Education Agencies (LEAs) and the State. As a result of this Workgroup's recommendations, three school bus transportation bills were passed into law in 2025:

Increased Van Size - This act amends the definition of a "pupil transportation vehicle" to a vehicle constructed to seat not more than ten (10) passengers plus the operator, rather than the existing limit of eight (8) passengers. It is RIDE's intent to maximize the usage of these vehicles for statewide transportation whenever possible and practical.

Temporary School Bus Driver Licenses - The act provides that the ten (10) hour training course required of applicants to be a school bus driver would be abbreviated and reduced in time for applicants who also hold a valid commercial driver's license. This act also authorizes the division of motor vehicles to issue a temporary school bus driver license to certain persons who reside in states bordering Rhode Island and who meet other requirements

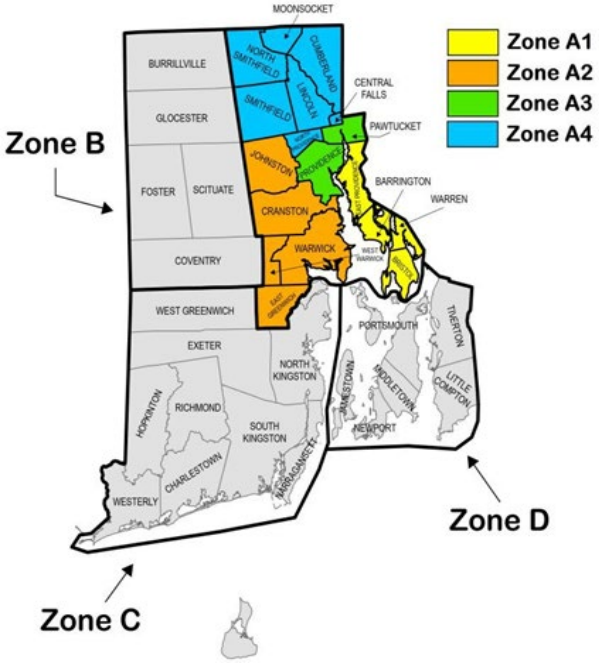
Live Digital Video Violation Systems - This act requires that all new school buses be equipped with live digital video school bus violation detection monitoring systems as of July 1, 2027. All buses, new and used, are required to have the monitoring systems installed by July 1, 2032. This act also provides that jurisdiction over all prosecutions based on evidence produced by a live digital video school bus violation detection monitoring system will be shared between the municipal courts and the traffic tribunal. This act also amends the distribution of revenues from fines imposed for violations of chapter 31 of title 51 ("School Bus Safety Enforcement")

Background:

RIDE currently provides home-to-school transportation services to 3,400 students across approximately 40 LEAs (Local Education Agency(s). The statewide system is presently divided into seven (7) zones. The current transportation providers for each zone, as well as other system specific data, are represented in the tables and graphics below. Current contracts with each bus operator are set to expire on June 30th of 2027.

Zone	Current Contractor	Students Transported	Routes Operated
Zone A1	First Student	300	122
Zone A2	Dattco	609	57
Zone A3	First Student	1238	29
Zone A4	Dattco	664	35
Zone B	Dattco	115	33
Zone C	Dattco	186	29
Zone D	Amaral	29	29

Transportation Zones



Zone	# of Vans and Transit Vans Operated	# of Type A School Buses Operated	# of Type A Wheelchair School Buses Operated	# of Type B, C, D School Buses Operated
Zone A1	**29**	**52**	**13**	**28**
Zone A2	**32**	**10**	**5**	**10**
Zone A3	**6**	**9**	**3**	**11**
Zone A4	**22**	**9**	**2**	**2**
Zone B	**21**	**4**	**2**	**6**
Zone C	**19**	**3**	**1**	**6**
Zone D	**18**	**6**	**4**	**1**

Zone	# of Special Ed Routes Operated	# of PCCT Routes Operated	# of Mckinney Vento Routes Operated	Average Route Time incl. Deadhead (hours.minutes)	Average route Time without Deadhead (hours.minutes)
Zone A1	84	28	10	4.43	3.28
Zone A2	44	9	4	5.18	3.36
Zone A3	16	11	2	4.28	3.18
Zone A4	28	3	4	5.32	3.43
Zone B	21	7	5	5.12	3.29
Zone C	18	8	3	6.07	3.55
Zone D	23	2	4	7.05	3.27

Zone	Number of Monitors Utilized	Number of Aides Utilized	Number of 1-on-1 Aides Utilized
Zone A1	**23**	**90**	**5**
Zone A2	**4**	**48**	**4**
Zone A3	**10**	**16**	**10**
Zone A4	**4**	**29**	**4**
Zone B	**6**	**22**	**0**
Zone C	**8**	**20**	**0**
Zone D	**4**	**24**	**1**

SECTION C: QUESTIONS TO FIELD

Inquiries Regarding Potential Barriers to Entry:

1. What, if anything, may prevent your company from bidding on this scope of work?
2. What contract structure(s) would make participation in RIDE's Statewide Transportation System (STS) more feasible for your organization? For example, would any of the following potential contract structures make it more likely that your organization would bid on this scope of work?
    - Multiple vendor awards per zone
    - Subdividing larger zones into more, smaller zones
    - Allowing subcontracting or partnerships within zones and/or across zones
3. What minimum route density or fleet size makes bidding on a zone more viable for your organization?
4. What support (e.g., yard space, fuel access, maintenance facilities, etc.) could the State provide or assist with that would make it more likely for your organization to bid?

Operational Efficiencies:

1. In general, please describe your company's deadhead reduction strategies.
2. Please describe your company's preventive maintenance efficiency metrics and how those relate to how your organization best-manages its preventative maintenance program.
3. Please describe your company's driver scheduling efficiency tools and metrics.

Cost Controls:

1. How do you address and apply cost per bus per day? (no pricing info, but explain your methodology)
2. What is your company's cost per mile methodology?
3. What is your company's spare ratio philosophy?
4. How do you address and apply average driver hours per route?

Routing:

1. How do you or would you collaborate with a centralized routing authority, such as the Statewide System Manager?
2. What Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) do you believe the State should be using to measure routing efficiency across the STS?
3. What is your company or organization's reasonable timeframe to turn around service delivery for any route changes or additions within the proposed scope?

Please disclose your company practices in the following areas:

1. Driver recruitment pipeline
2. Training hours per driver
3. Maintenance intervals

Timeline:

1. RIDE plans to publish the RFP in the late spring of 2026, with responses due in summer of 2026. RIDE plans to announce contract award(s) in November of 2026, ahead of a service start of July 1,2027 for the summer school session.

    a) Is there anything your company or organization would modify within the proposed timeline that would be more conducive to your success?
    b) We are aware of the national driver shortage. Does your company or organization feel like the above timeline allows for the necessary time to recruit the number of drivers needed per what is currently outlined in this scope?
    c) How many routes would you likely bid on in an upcoming RFP?
    d) How does this timeline impact your fleet construct?

Information Gathering Templates (Optional):

RIDE is interested in learning more about potential bidders' school bus operations and services offered. Please complete the following using the templates provided.

- Staffing model
- Safety and compliance
- Technological capabilities

Summary:

The response should include a brief narrative with the highlights, key attributes, and distinguishing points of the respondent's proposed approach. The narrative should also explain how the response aligns with the specific goals and objectives stated in the introduction section, with your responses to the questions outlined above, and in the documents linked therein.

RFI Response:

The following outline is intended to standardize and structure responses for ease of analysis. *Do NOT include a cost proposal with the RFI response as cost shall not be considered with this RFI.*

SECTION E. DISCLAIMER

This Request for Information is solely for information and planning purposes and does not constitute a request for proposal or an invitation to bid. All information received in response to the RFI and marked as “Proprietary” shall be deemed to be confidential.